



I have a strict budget of \$30,000 to start a late-night boba tea shop on Green Street in Champaign. To save money, it will only operate from 10 PM to 3 AM. Provide a detailed startup cost breakdown and evaluate if this is financially feasible.

A traditional brick-and-mortar boba shop on Green Street is not realistically achievable on a total startup budget of \$30,000; to make it viable, you would need to radically change the concept (e.g., kiosk/ghost kitchen, shared space, or mobile setup) and even then it will be tight. ^[1] ^[2] ^[3] ^[4]

1. Key reality check: Green Street rent

Recent Green Street retail listings show base rents around \$34–36 per square foot per year, or roughly \$2.80–3.00 per square foot per month. ^[2] ^[1]

- A very small 600–800 sq ft space (bare minimum for a shop with prep + tiny front) at \$3/sq ft/month is:
 - 600 sq ft → about \$1,800/month base rent. ^[2]
 - 800 sq ft → about \$2,400/month base rent. ^[2]
- Many Green Street leases are triple-net (you also pay taxes, insurance, CAM), often adding several hundred dollars per month. ^[2]

Even before buildout and equipment, you would typically need first month's rent, last month's rent, and a security deposit, so you could easily be tying up \$6,000–\$8,000+ of your \$30,000 just in lease-related cash.

2. Typical boba shop startup cost ranges

Industry and operator estimates for a standalone boba shop in the U.S. show:

- Typical total startup cost: \$75,000–\$250,000 for rent, buildout, equipment, supplies, licenses, and staffing. ^[4]
- Independent bubble tea stores often land in the \$50,000–\$200,000 range depending on size and customization, with interior setup alone up to \$30,000 and equipment \$5,000–\$30,000. ^[3]

- Some café/boba buildout anecdotes show \$150k+ just for construction and equipment in 800 sq ft spaces.^[5]

Your \$30,000 is well below the *low end* of typical ranges for a full dedicated shop, especially in a prime campus corridor like Green Street.^{[3] [4]}

3. Lean, late-night-only concept: sample startup budget

If you insist on trying a super-lean late-night boba model (10 PM–3 AM, minimal seating, heavy emphasis on to-go and delivery), a *very optimistic* bare-bones budget might look like this:

One-time startup costs (very lean scenario)

- Lease costs to start
 - First month, last month, deposit (600–700 sq ft): \$6,000–\$8,000.^{[1] [2]}
- Basic leasehold improvements (assuming previously food-usable space to avoid new plumbing/grease trap)
 - Minor counters, paint, lighting, basic signage: \$8,000–\$12,000 (this is far below typical \$30k+ interior setups).^{[6] [3]}
- Used/lean equipment
 - 2–3 commercial blenders, fridge/freezer, undercounter fridge, prep tables, sink upgrades, tea brewers, water heater, sealing machine, basic POS/tablet: \$8,000–\$12,000 if sourced used/discounted.^{[7] [3]}
- Licenses, permits, insurance, legal/accounting setup
 - Health department, business registration, food license, liability insurance, basic legal/accounting: \$2,000–\$3,000 (varies by exact requirements).
- Initial inventory and disposables
 - Tea, milk/creamers, syrups, toppings (boba, jellies), cups, lids, straws, cleaning supplies: \$1,500–\$2,000.^{[7] [3]}
- Initial marketing
 - Branding, social media content, student promos, opening events, flyers: \$500–\$1,000.^[7]

Even in this very optimistic scenario, your one-time startup costs already land around \$26,000–\$38,000, and that assumes:

- You find a small space already set up for food/beverage use.
- You accept a very minimal interior and mostly second-hand equipment.
- You avoid costly construction and specialty plumbing.

That means \$30,000 is barely enough just to open the door once, with little or nothing left as working capital.

4. Operating costs and working capital

You also need cash to survive the first few months:

- Fixed monthly costs (rough estimate)
 - Base rent (600–700 sq ft): \$1,800–\$2,100.^{[1] [2]}
 - NNN + utilities (electric, water, gas, internet): \$600–\$1,000.
 - Insurance, software subscriptions, small fees: \$200–\$400.
- Labor (late-night hours)
 - You plus 1–2 staff per shift for safety and speed. Even if you pay part-time students and limit hours to 5 per night, 7 nights/week, you could be around \$2,000–\$4,000/month in payroll including payroll taxes if you do not work every shift yourself.
- Ingredients and disposables
 - For a small, early-stage boba shop, a few hundred to \$1,000+ per month depending on sales volume.^{[3] [7]}

A realistic lean monthly operating budget can easily reach \$4,500–\$7,000+ once you include rent, utilities, labor, and supplies.

To be safe, most guides suggest several months of working capital beyond buildout costs so you can survive before you reach consistent revenue. With only \$30,000 total, you would likely have less than one month of true runway if buildout+opening costs consume the bulk of your cash.^[4]

5. Revenue and feasibility of 10 PM–3 AM only

Late-night hours do tap into a high-demand UIUC student segment (post-study, post-bar food and drink), and Green Street traffic is intense, but just 5 hours per night creates constraints:

- You lose daytime and early evening revenue when many students also buy boba as a casual drink or study companion.
- To cover, say, \$6,000/month in expenses from just 150 hours of operation per month (5h × 30 days), you need to generate \$40/hour in gross profit just to break even, before paying yourself.
- If your average ticket is around \$6–8, you might need 15–20 transactions/hour at healthy margins just to cover costs, which is ambitious for a brand-new store with no daytime visibility.

Given typical industry startup ranges and the density of costs on Green Street, the bigger problem isn't only the limited hours; it's that your capital base is too small to (a) secure and build a space, and (b) carry losses while you grow.^{[4] [1] [3] [2]}

6. More realistic paths within a \$30k budget

If you want to stay around \$30,000 total, you likely need to change the vehicle rather than forcing a full shop:

- Kiosk inside an existing business
 - Negotiate a late-night boba counter inside a restaurant or café that closes early.
 - You avoid a separate lease, and your buildout/equipment can be much lighter (a cart, blenders, small fridges, sealing machine).
 - This is where lower equipment budgets like €2,000–€5,000 for basic setups are more realistic.^[7]
- Ghost kitchen / shared commercial kitchen
 - Rent a shared kitchen, focus on delivery and pickup only during late-night hours.
 - Lower front-of-house buildout cost, more budget for equipment and marketing.
- Food truck or trailer
 - A used concession trailer or truck sometimes falls into the \$20,000–\$50,000 range total (vehicle plus equipment) depending on condition; this might still require some extra capital beyond \$30,000, but it's closer than a Green Street storefront.
- Pop-up model first
 - Run pop-ups at student events, night markets, and collaborations with bars or restaurants to prove demand and build a brand, while saving more capital or seeking investors.

7. Bottom line

- A dedicated late-night boba shop on Green Street with only \$30,000 in total startup capital is not financially feasible under normal lease, buildout, and equipment costs.^{[1] [3] [4] [2]}
- To make a boba concept viable at that budget, you should consider a kiosk, shared space, ghost kitchen, or pop-up strategy first, then use traction and cash flow to move into a full Green Street storefront once you have significantly more capital (realistically \$75k+, and often well over \$100k).

If you want, I can next help you design a concrete \$30k plan for a Green-Street-adjacent kiosk or ghost-kitchen boba concept (including menu, staffing, and a lean budget).

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1. <https://www.loopnet.com/Listing/505-E-Green-St-Champaign-IL/38335776/>

2. <https://www.loopnet.com/Listing/602-E-Green-St-Champaign-IL/35367286/>

3. <https://www.onezo.us/post/bubble-tea-business>

4. <https://www.chowbus.com/blog/how-much-does-it-cost-to-open-a-boba-shop>

5. https://www.reddit.com/r/boba/comments/1exyvw1/total_cost_of_buildout_a_milk_tea_franchise/

6. https://www.reddit.com/r/coffeeshopowners/comments/1jkg4rx/build_out_prices/

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